

Everything you write on the job will have some kind of persuasive purpose—to convince the reader of your professionalism, convey an appealing company image, promote good relations, or all of these. But in some situations, persuasion will be your central goal. In these cases, your readers will hold a certain position, and your task will be to move them from this position to one that is more favorable to you and/or your company. Meeting this challenge requires careful analysis, strategic thinking, and skillful writing.

But the rewards of persuasive communication are many. Read on to see how to boost your persuasion savvy. ■

### LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- LO 7-1** Describe important strategies for writing any persuasive message.
- LO 7-2** Write skillful persuasive requests that begin indirectly, develop convincing reasoning, make a call to action, and close with goodwill.
- LO 7-3** Discuss ethical concerns regarding sales messages.
- LO 7-4** Describe the planning steps for direct mail or email sales messages.
- LO 7-5** Compose sales messages that gain attention, present persuasive appeals, use appropriate visual elements, and effectively drive for action.
- LO 7-6** Write well-organized and persuasive proposals.

# THE PREDOMINANCE OF INDIRECTNESS IN PERSUASIVE MESSAGES

By definition, persuasive messages are written to potentially uncooperative readers; that is why persuasion is necessary. For this reason, it is often best to organize persuasive messages in an **indirect order**. Preparing the reader to accept your idea is a much better strategy than announcing the idea from the start and then having to argue uphill through the rest of the message. Ideally, you should organize each persuasive message so that, from the title or subject line to the end, your readers will agree with you. If you try to have them on your side from start to finish, you'll have your best chance of success.

Although indirectness works for most persuasive messages, sometimes you will want to use a **direct approach**. For example, if you know your reader prefers directness or if you believe your readers will discard your message unless you get to the point early, then directness is in order. As we discuss later in this chapter, proposals in response to specific requests may also use directness.

In the following pages we first provide general advice for effective persuasion using the indirect approach. We then explain how the indirect order is used in two kinds of persuasive messages: the persuasive request and the sales message. Finally, we cover another important category of persuasive writing: proposals. These, as you will see, can use either the direct or indirect pattern, depending on whether they are invited or uninvited.

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**LO 7-1** Describe important strategies for writing any persuasive message.

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## GENERAL ADVICE ABOUT PERSUASION

All our previous advice about adapting your messages to your readers comes into play with persuasive messages—only more so. Moving your reader from an uninterested or even resistant position to an interested, cooperative one is a major accomplishment. To achieve it, keep the following advice in mind.

### Know Your Readers

For any kind of persuasive message, thinking about your subject from your readers' point of view is critical. To know what kind of appeals will succeed with your readers, you need to know as much as you can about their values, interests, and



*Knowing your readers enables you to target their interests.*

needs. Companies specializing in email and direct-mail campaigns spend a great deal of money to acquire this kind of information. Using a variety of research techniques, they gather **demographic information** (such as age, gender, income, and geographic location) and **psychographic information** (such as social, political, and personal preferences) about their target audience. They also develop mailing lists based on prior shows of interest from consumers and purchase mailing lists from other organizations that have had success with certain audiences.

If you don't have these resources, you can use other means to learn as much as possible about the intended readers. You can talk with customer service about the kinds of calls they're getting, study the company's customer database, chat with people around the water cooler or online, and run ideas past colleagues. Good persuasion depends on knowledge as well as on imagination and logic.

### Choose and Develop Targeted Reader Benefits

No one is persuaded to do something for no reason. Sometimes their reasons for acting are related to **tangible** or measurable rewards. For example, they will save money, save time, or acquire some kind of desired object. But often, the rewards that persuade are **intangible**. People may want to make their lives easier, gain prestige, or have more freedom. Or perhaps they want to identify with a larger cause, feel that they are helping others, or do the right thing. In your quest for the appeals that will win your



*Extrinsic benefits like giveaways can add incentive, but intrinsic benefits are usually stronger.*

readers over, do not underestimate the power of intangible benefits, especially when you can pair them with tangible rewards.

When selecting the **reader benefits** to feature in your persuasive messages, bear in mind that such benefits can be intrinsic, extrinsic, or a combination. **Intrinsic benefits** are benefits that readers will get automatically by complying with your request. For example, if you are trying to persuade people to attend your company's awards dinner, the pleasure of sharing in their colleagues' successes will be intrinsic to the event. Door prizes would be an **extrinsic benefit**. We might classify the meal itself as a combination—not really the main feature of the event but definitely central to it. Intrinsic benefits are tightly linked to what you're asking people to do, while extrinsic ones are added on and more short-lived. Let intrinsic benefits do the main persuasive work. Focusing too much on extrinsic benefits can actually cheapen your product or service in the readers' eyes.

When presenting your reader benefits, be sure the readers can see exactly how the benefits will help them. The literature on selling makes a useful distinction between **product features** and reader benefits. If you say that a wireless service uses a certain kind of technology, you're describing a feature. If you say that the technology results in fewer missed or dropped calls, you're describing a benefit. Benefits persuade by enabling readers to envision the features of the recommended product or action in their own worlds.

One common technique for achieving this goal is to use what we call **scenario painting**—a description that pictures the reader in a sample situation enjoying the promised benefits. Here is an example of scenario painting from a Web site promoting a tour of Warner Brothers Studio:

Led by our top tour guides, this exclusive tour takes you into the craft shops where artisans create sets, props, costumes and more. You'll visit working production sets to talk to key crew people, watch as Foley artists create sound effects for film and TV, and get an up close and personal look at the magic of movie making. In addition, your private group will dine in the studio commissary where you have the real opportunity to dine with the stars.

Scenario painting is common in sales messages, but you can also use it to good advantage in other persuasive messages, even internal ones. Whatever your persuasive situation or strategy, be sure to provide enough detail for readers to see how they will benefit from what you are asking them to do.

## Make Good Use of Three Kinds of Appeals

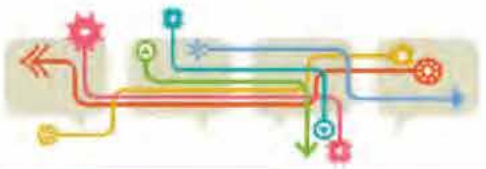
The first acknowledged expert on persuasion, the Greek philosopher Aristotle, lived almost 2,500 years ago, but many of his core concepts are still widely taught and used. Of particular value is his famous categorizing of persuasive appeals into three kinds, summarized in Exhibit 7-1 (next page): those based on **logic** (*logos*), those based on **emotion** (*pathos*), and those based on the **character** of the speaker (*ethos*). All three kinds come into play in every persuasive message—in fact, one might say, in every kind of message. But as the writer of a persuasive message, you will need to think especially carefully about how to manage these appeals and which ones to emphasize given your intended audience.



*Painting a vivid scene showing the benefits can help you persuade.*



# workplace scenario



## Raising Funds for a Worthy Cause

You're a mid-level manager for Arslan, one of the largest custodial services companies in your city. Like many others in the company, you devote some of your personal time to serving the community. Arslan wants you to do this volunteer work for the sake of good public relations. You want to do it because it is personally and professionally rewarding.

Currently, as chair of the fundraising committee of the city's Junior Achievement

program, you head all efforts to get financial support for the program from local businesspeople. The committee can contact some of these potential donors by phone, but there are too many for you to be able to reach all of them this way.

At its meeting today, the Junior Achievement board of directors discussed various solutions. One director suggested using a fundraising letter. The board accepted the idea with enthusiasm. With just as much

enthusiasm, it gave you the assignment of writing the letter.

As you view the assignment, it is not a routine letter-writing problem. Although the local businesspeople are probably generous, they are not likely to part with money without good reason. In fact, their first reaction to a request for money is likely to be negative. So you will need to overcome their resistance in order to persuade them. Your task is indeed challenging.

Whether written to internal or external readers, requests that are likely to be resisted require a slow, deliberate approach.

As you plan your message, consider what kind of logical appeals you might use. Saved money? Saved time? A more dependable or effective product? How about emotional appeals? Higher status? More sex appeal? Increased popularity? And don't neglect appeals based on character. What kind of image of yourself and your company will resonate with the reader? Should you get a celebrity or expert to endorse your product or to serve as the spokesperson? Not only when planning but also when revising your persuasive message, assess your appeals. Be sure to choose and develop the ones most likely to persuade your audience.

## Make It Easy for Your Readers to Comply

Sometimes writers focus so much on creating persuasive appeals that they put insufficient thought into making the requested action as clear and easy to perform as possible. If you want people to give money or buy your product, tell them where and how to do it, and supply a preaddressed mailing envelope or a Web address if applicable. If you want employees to give suggestions for

improving products or operations, tell them exactly where and how to submit their ideas, and make it easy for them to do so. If you want people to remember to work more safely or conserve on supplies, give them specific techniques for achieving these goals and include reminders at the actual locations where they need to remember what to do. Making the desired action specific and easy to perform is a key part of moving your readers from resistance to compliance with your request.

With this general advice in mind, we now turn to the three main types of persuasive writing in business: persuasive requests, sales messages, and proposals.

**LO 7-2** Write skillful persuasive requests that begin indirectly, develop convincing reasoning, make a call to action, and close with goodwill.

## PERSUASIVE REQUESTS

At many points in your career—starting with your job search—you will need to make **persuasive requests**. Perhaps, as in the Workplace Scenario above, you will be asked to write a fundraising message. Perhaps you will need to ask your management for another staff position or for special equipment. You may need to persuade a potential client to join you in a meeting so that you can demonstrate the benefits of your products. Or maybe you will be trying to persuade your employees to change their behavior in some way.

### EXHIBIT 7-1 The Three Main Types of Appeals

- Logical (*logos*)—makes a rational argument
- Emotional (*pathos*)—arouses certain feelings and values
- Character based (*ethos*)—projects appealing traits of the writer or speaker



Whether written to internal or external readers, requests that are likely to be resisted require a slow, deliberate approach. In essence, you must persuade the reader that he or she should grant your request before you actually state it. Such an achievement requires that you carefully plan your persuasive strategy.

## Determining Your Strategy

Figuring out the best persuasive approach involves three interrelated tasks: determining what you want, figuring out your readers' likely reactions, and deciding upon a persuasive strategy that will overcome reader objections and evoke a positive response.

Think carefully about your actual goals for your persuasive request. A request for a one-time-only donation might be written very differently from a request that is intended to create a long-time, multiple donor. If you were convincing employees to leave the parking places next to the building for customers' use, you would write a very different message if it were the third rather than the first request. Your goals, considered in the context of your organization's goals and your relationship with your readers, are key shapers of your persuasive message.

To anticipate how your readers will react to your request, consider everything you know about them and then put yourself in their shoes. Look at the request as they are likely to see it. Figure out what's in it for them and how to overcome any objections they may have. From this thinking and imagining, your plan should emerge.

The specific plan you develop will depend on the facts of the case. You may be able to show that your reader stands to gain in time, money, or other tangible benefits. Or you may be able to show that your reader will benefit in goodwill or prestige. In some cases, you may persuade readers by appealing to their love of beauty, excitement, serenity, or other emotions. In different cases, you may be able to persuade readers by appealing to the pleasant feeling that comes from doing a good turn. You decide on the benefits that will be most likely to win over your readers.

A special kind of persuasive request is one that casts the request as a problem–solution message. With this strategy, you first present a problem that you and the readers share—called the **common-ground persuasion technique**—and then show how doing as you propose will solve the problem for all concerned. Many fundraising letters use this technique, giving us striking facts about the current economic climate, the environment, or living conditions in a certain area of the world. But this strategy can also be a powerful one for internal audiences who



*Many times in your career you will need to ask for something. This chapter tells you how.*

might not be receptive to a straightforward proposal for action but who share your opinion that something needs to be done.

A persuasive request situation is a special opportunity for analysis, creativity, and judgment. With careful use of all three, you can plan messages that will change your readers' minds and move them to action.

## Gaining Attention in the Opening

In the indirect messages discussed in Chapter 6, the goal of the opening is to set up the explanation for the negative news. The opening of a persuasive request has a similar goal: to lead into your central strategy. But the opening of a persuasive request has an additional goal: to gain attention.



*Many persuasive messages arrive uninvited, and they compete with many other messages. Unless they gain the reader's attention at the beginning, they are likely to end up in the recycle bin.*

You need to draw your reader in with the opening of your persuasive message because you are writing to a person who has not invited your message and may not agree with your goal. An interesting beginning is a good step toward getting this person in a receptive mood.

Determine what your reader will find compelling. It might be a statement that arouses curiosity, or it might be a statement offering or implying a reader benefit. Because questions get people thinking, they are often effective openings. The following examples indicate the possibilities.

From the cover letter of a questionnaire seeking the opinions of medical doctors:

What, in your opinion as a medical doctor, is the future of the private practice of medicine?

From a message requesting contributions for orphaned children:

While you and I dined heartily last night, 31 orphans at San Pablo Mission had only dried beans to eat.

From a message seeking the cooperation of business leaders in promoting a fair:

What would your profits be if 300,000 free-spending visitors came to our town during a single week?

If writing your request in the form of a problem–solution message, you should start with a goal that you and the readers share. For example, let’s say that a project manager in your company has retired and that you want to recommend his capable administrative assistant as his replacement. Since no member of the support staff has ever broken into the managerial ranks, any direct proposal to promote your candidate will likely be resisted. To get readers on your side from the beginning, you could start your message with facts that everyone can agree upon: that someone has retired, that his or her duties are important, and that someone capable needs to be found quickly. Your subject line for an email along these lines might be something like, “Reassigning Jim Martin’s Duties” (which everyone supports), not “Promoting Kathy Pearson” (which your readers will resist).

Whatever the case, the form of indirectness that you choose for your opening should engage your readers right away and get



This direct, bland request is not likely to persuade.

Dear Mr. Williams:

Will you please donate to the local Junior Achievement program? We have set \$50 as a fair minimum for businesses to give. But larger amounts would be appreciated.

The organization badly needs your support. Currently, about 900 young people will not get to participate in Junior Achievement activities unless more money is raised.

If you do not already know about Junior Achievement, let me explain. Junior Achievement is an organization for high school students. They work with local business executives to form small businesses and then operate the businesses. In the process, they learn about our economic system. This is a good thing, and it deserves our help.

Hoping to receive your generous donation,

Jane Monroe



## If writing your request in the form of a problem-solution message, you should start with a goal that you and the readers share.

them thinking along the lines that will lead to their approval of your request.

### Developing the Appeal

Following the opening, you should proceed with your goal of persuading. Your task here is a logical and orderly presentation of the reasoning you have selected.

As with any argument intended to convince, you should do more than merely list points. You should develop the points with convincing details. Since you are trying to penetrate a neutral or resistant mind, you need to make good use of the you-viewpoint. You need to pay careful attention to the meanings of your words and the clarity of your expression. You need to use logic and emotion appropriately and project an

appealing image (see the Communication Matters feature on the next page for a list of persuasive personal qualities). And because your reader may become impatient if your appeal is not clear, you need to make every word count.

### Making the Request Clearly and Positively

After you have done your persuading, move to the action you seek. You have tried to prepare the reader for what you want. If you have done that well, the reader should be ready to accept your request.

Dear Mr. Williams:

Right now—right here in our city—620 teenagers are running 37 corporations. The kids run the whole show; their only adult help comes from business professionals who work with them.

Last September these young people applied for charters and elected officers. They created plans for business operations. For example, one group planned to build Web sites for local small businesses. Another elected to conduct a rock concert. Yet another planned to publish electronic newsletters for area corporations. After determining their plans, the kids issued stock—and sold it, too. With the proceeds from stock sales, they began their operations. This May they will liquidate their companies and account to their stockholders for their profits or losses.

What's behind these impressive accomplishments? As you've probably guessed, it's Junior Achievement. Since 1919, this nonprofit organization has been teaching school kids of all ages about business, economics, and entrepreneurship. Thanks to partnerships between volunteers and teachers, these students gain hands-on experience with real business operations while learning the fundamentals of economics and financial responsibility. They also learn cooperation and problem solving. It's a win-win situation for all involved.

To continue to succeed, Junior Achievement needs all of us behind it. During the 13 years the program has been in our city, it has had enthusiastic support from local business leaders. But with over 900 students on the waiting list, our plans for next year call for expansion. That's why, as a volunteer myself, I ask that you help make the program available to more youngsters by contributing \$50 (it's deductible). By helping to cover the cost of materials, special events, and scholarships, you'll be preparing more students for a bright future in business.

Please make your donation now by completing our online contribution form at [www.juniorachievement.org](http://www.juniorachievement.org). You will be doing a good service—for our kids, for our schools, and for our community.

Best regards,

Jane Monroe



This indirect, interesting request has a much greater chance of success.

# communication matters

## The Ingredients of Successful Fundraising

Expert fundraiser Jerold Panas conducted several focus groups to find out what makes fundraising successful. The answers boiled down to “three Es”—plus one “I”:

- Empathy—the ability to understand the audience’s values and interests
- Energy—the determination to put sufficient work into the fundraising effort
- Enthusiasm—the fundraiser’s obvious commitment to the cause
- Integrity—the fundraiser’s sincerity and truthfulness

**Source:** *Asking: A 59-Minute Guide to Everything Board Members, Volunteers, and Staff Must Know to Secure the Gift*, rev. ed. (Medfield, MA: Emerson & Church, 2009) 17–20, print.

As with negative messages, your request requires careful word choice. You should avoid words that bring to mind images and ideas that might work against you. Words that suggest reasons for refusing are especially harmful, as in this example:

I am aware that businesspeople in your position have little free time to give, but will you please consider accepting an assignment to the board of directors of the Children’s Fund?

The following positive tie-in with a major point in the persuasion strategy does a much better job:

Your organizing skills and stature in the community would make you an ideal board member for the Children’s Fund.

Whether your request should end your message will depend on the situation. In some cases, you will profit by following the request with additional persuasive material. This technique is especially effective when your reader needs a lot of convincing. In cases where your request is relatively simple, won’t cost the reader much, and isn’t likely to be resisted, you can end your message with the request. Even here, though, you combine or follow the request with wording that makes the reader feel good about doing as you ask (see the sample messages on pages 165–166).

## Summarizing the Plan for Requests

From the preceding discussion, the general plan for persuasive requests can be summarized as follows:

- Open with words that (1) gain attention and (2) set up the strategy.
- Develop the strategy using persuasive language and the you-viewpoint.

- Make the request clearly and without negatives (1) either at the end of the message or (2) followed by words that continue the persuasive appeal.

## Contrasting Examples of a Persuasive Request

The persuasive request is illustrated by contrasting letters that ask businesspeople to donate to Junior Achievement. The first message is direct and bland. The second message, which follows the indirect approach and provides convincing details, is much more likely to succeed.

**a selfish blunt approach** The weaker letter (page 162) begins with the request. Because the requested action is something the reader probably doesn’t want to do, the direct beginning is likely to get a negative reaction. In addition, the comments about how much to give tend to lecture rather than suggest. Some explanation follows, but it is weak and scant. In general, the letter is poorly written. It makes little use of the you-viewpoint. Perhaps its greatest fault is that the persuasion comes too late. The selfish close is a weak reminder of the action requested.

### skillful persuasion using the indirect order

The message on page 163 follows the recommended indirect pattern. Its opening generates interest and sets up the persuasive strategy. Notice the effective use of the you-viewpoint throughout. Not until the reader has been sold on the merits of the request does the message ask the question. It does this clearly and directly. The final words leave the reader thinking about the benefits that a yes answer will give.

## SALES MESSAGES

One of the most widely disseminated forms of business communication is the **sales message**. It is such an important component of most businesses’ sales strategies that it has become an elaborate, highly professionalized genre, shaped by extensive consumer research. Think about the typical sales letter that you receive. Careful attention has been paid to the message on the envelope, to the kinds of pieces inside, and to the visual appeal of those pieces, as well as to the text of the letter itself. Clearly, advertising professionals produce many of these mailings, as well as much of the fundraising literature that we receive. You can also see a professional’s hand in many of the sales emails that appear in your in-box, as well as in other sales communications, such as blogs, Facebook pages, and white papers. Why, then, should you study sales writing?

As a businessperson, you will often find yourself in the position of helping to shape a major sales campaign or contribute to its success through social networking. You may have valuable insight into your product’s benefits and your potential customers. You need to be familiar with the conventions for sales messages and to be able to offer your own good ideas for their success.





## A Persuasive Internal Request (Using a Central Emotional Appeal Supported by Logical and Character-Based Appeals)

The writer wants employees to participate in the company's annual blood drive. He needs to convince them of the importance of the drive

and overcome their likely objections. This message will be distributed to employees' mailboxes.



Department of Community Relations  
Mail Location 12  
123 Jackson Street  
Edison, Colorado 80864  
(719) 777-4444  
CommunityRelations@Amberly.com

February 27, 2014

*Opens with an attention-getting, you-focused question*

Did you help save Brad Meyer's life?

*Uses a character-based appeal; invites the reader to identify with these "lifesavers"*

A few years ago, an employee of Amberly was driving to a friend's wedding when an oncoming car, operated by a drunk driver, swerved across the center line. Brad doesn't remember the crash. But he does remember two months spent in the hospital, two months of surgery and therapy.

*Tells an engaging story with specific details*

Without the help of people like us, Brad would not have lived. Some Amberly employees save lives regularly. We're blood donors. Please be a lifesaver and join us on Friday, March 19, for Amberly's annual blood drive.

Your help is needed for a successful drive.

*Avoids words such as "draw blood" or "needle" that would bring unpleasant thoughts to mind*

**Giving blood is simple.** The entire process will take less than 45 minutes.

**Giving blood is safe.** Experienced health professionals from the Steinmetz Blood Center will be on site to conduct the procedure exactly as they would in a clinical setting.

**Giving blood is convenient.** The Steinmetz staff will be in Room 401, Building B, between 9:00 a.m. and 3:00 p.m. To save time, make an appointment to donate. Call the Steinmetz Blood Center at 569-1170.

**Giving blood is important.** Nobody knows who will need blood next, but one thing is certain—it will be available only if healthy, caring people take time to give it. Brad's accident required 110 units—more than 12 gallons—of blood. Because 110 people set aside 45 minutes, Brad Meyer has a lifetime of minutes to be grateful.

*Addresses likely reader objections*

*Recalls the emotion-based opening and links it to a logical appeal: You or someone in your family might benefit*

Take a few moments now to make your pledge on the reverse side of this letter. Then return it to the Community Relations department, Mail Location 12, by March 15.

From Brad and from other families—like yours and mine—who might need it in the days to come,

Thank you,  
*John M. Piper*  
John M. Piper  
Director, Community Relations

*Makes the requested action clear and easy*



## case illustration

# A Persuasive Email to Members of a Professional Organization

The writer of this message, the president of the American Society for Training and Development (ASTD), uses character appeal as

well as logic and emotion to persuade readers to participate in a survey.

**Help Shape the ASTD 2013 State of the Industry Report**

File Edit View Tools Message Help

Reply Reply All Forward Print Delete Addresses

**From:** Tony Bingham  
**Date:** Monday, 8/18/2013 9:00 a.m.  
**To:** Kathryn Smythe  
**Subject:** Help Shape the ASTD 2013 State of the Industry Report

*Opening paragraph includes a personal invitation from an important person and appeals to the reader's desire to help*

Dear Kathryn,

ASTD is currently collecting data for its 16th annual State of the Industry Report. I'd like to personally invite your organization to participate in the survey that provides crucial data for the report. The greater the submissions, the more meaningful the report is for the entire learning profession. With your contribution, we are able to effectively measure and report critical learning and development information including investments, expenditures, practices, and outcomes, across a variety of industries and organizations.

*Makes the reader want to be part of a meaningful, well-respected project*

*Reassures the reader that honest responses will be kept anonymous*

The ASTD State of the Industry Report is widely quoted by business and industry analysts around the world, and continues to be a leading source of credible statistics about employee learning. ASTD Research handles participant data with the strictest confidence and sensitivity, and we report results in aggregates and averages that do not identify participating organizations or organization-specific data. Having your organization's data included is a tremendous contribution to our accurate analyses of important learning and development benchmarks for 2012.

*Stresses the value of the reader's contribution*

*Makes clear who should fill out the survey and how to access it*

If you are not the person responsible for this, would you please share this request with your organization's Chief Learning Officer or senior learning executive? You can access the survey at this link:  
<https://survey.astd.org/se.ashx?s=34B40469374EE2B4>

*Ends with appreciation and a reminder of the importance of the reader's participation*

Each participant will receive a complimentary download of the ASTD 2013 State of the Industry Report when it is released in November (a \$499 value). We appreciate your time and willingness to participate in this important industry benchmark.

*Offers a persuasive tangible benefit*

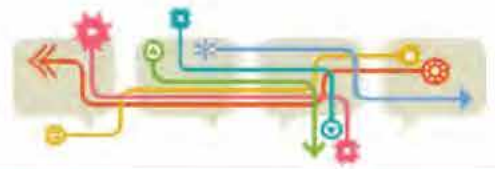
Sincerely,

Tony Bingham  
ASTD President and CEO

ASTD | 1640 King Street | Box 1443 | Alexandria, VA 22313 | United States  
[Unsubscribe](#) from future marketing messages from ASTD



# workplace scenario



## Generating More Customers for Your Business

Play the role of Zach Miller, a student in your university's college of business. You've had your own house-painting business ever since you started college. So far, you've gained your customers through word of mouth only, but you think it's time to expand.

You've got two buddies willing to come on board if you can generate enough business for them to work full time in the summer months and part time in the spring and fall.

You've decided that your first step in growing the business will be to advertise your services to the faculty and staff of your school. After getting permission to post your message to the listservs of several offices and academic departments, you sit down to think through what you want to say.

Considering your audience, you decide to reveal to them that you're a student. Given the line of work they're in, your readers obviously

like the feeling of helping young people succeed. On the other hand, you'll need to overcome any concern that the job you'll do will be less than professional. As you start figuring out your persuasive details, you realize that it may be a good idea to include links to other information. Hmm . . . this message is going to take some careful planning in order to be effective. The following sections will help you think through your options.

In addition, knowledge of selling techniques can help you in many of your other activities, especially the writing of other kinds of business messages. As we've said, most of them involve selling something—an idea, a line of reasoning, your company, yourself. Sales techniques are more valuable to you than you might think. After you have studied the remainder of this chapter, you should see why.

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**LO 7-3** Discuss ethical concerns regarding sales messages.

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## Questioning the Acceptability of Sales Messages

Sales messages are a controversial area of business communication, for two main reasons: They are often unwanted, and they sometimes use ethically dubious persuasive tactics. You probably know from your own experience that sales letters are not always received happily. Called “junk” mail, these mailings often go into the wastebasket or recycle bin without being read. They must be profitable, though, because they are still heavily used.

Sales messages sent by email may create even more hostility among intended customers. Angrily referred to as **spam**, unsolicited email sales messages have generated strong resistance among email users. Perhaps it is because these messages clutter in-boxes. Maybe it is because mass mailings place a heavy burden on Internet providers, driving up costs to the users. Or perhaps the fact that they invade the reader's privacy is to blame. Whatever the explanation, the resistance is real. You will need to consider these objections any time you use this sales medium.

Fortunately, a more acceptable form of email selling has developed. Called **permission-based email**, it permits potential customers to sign up for email promotions on a company's Web site or provide their email addresses to an email or phone



*Face-to-face selling is only part of the picture. Many sales occur through mail, email, Web-based media, and mobile messaging.*

marketer. The potential customers may be asked to indicate the products, services, and specific topics of their interest, or the company may be able to track those interests based on what the customer has searched for or ordered in the past. The marketers can then tailor their messages to the customer, and the customer will receive only what he or she wants. According to a recent report by *eMarketer*, 93 percent of U.S. online consumers have at least one email subscription, and it is by far their preferred method for hearing about sales or promotions (64 percent of those surveyed ranked this method first, as opposed to 25 percent for postal mail and 8 percent for social media sites). Permission-based email is thus a powerful sales practice, and it has helped address the problem of unwanted sales messages.<sup>1</sup>



As for the charge that persuasive messages use unfair persuasive tactics, this is, unfortunately, sometimes the case. The unfair tactics could range from deceptive wording and visuals to the omission of important information to the use of emotional elements that impair good judgment.

In a Missouri court case, Publishers Clearing House was found guilty of deception for direct mail stating that the recipients were already winners, when in fact they were not.<sup>2</sup> To consider a different example, one linen supply company sent a letter to parents of first-year students at a university telling them that the students would need to purchase extra-long sheets, offered by this company, to fit the extra-long beds on campus—but omitted the fact that only one dorm out of four had such beds. And it is well documented that images, because they work on an emotional level, persuade in ways that tend to bypass the viewers' reasoned judgment, leading some to question the ethics of such elements.<sup>3</sup>

Certain kinds of online sales messages are particularly obnoxious, such as giant pop-ups that obscure the screen. Some of these trap readers in a loop that they can't exit without restarting their computers or, in extreme cases, having to remove spyware or viruses.

Any persuasive message is, by its very nature, biased. The writer has a favored point of view and wants to persuade the

reader to adopt it. Therefore, considering the ethical dimension of your communication, while important for all types of messages, is especially critical for persuasive messages. Let your conscience and your ability to put yourself in the readers' shoes guide you as you consider how to represent your subject and win others to your cause.

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**LO 7-4** Describe the planning steps for direct mail or email sales messages.

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## Preparing to Write a Sales Message

Before you can begin writing a sales message, you must know all you can about the product or service you are selling. You simply cannot sell most goods and services unless you know them well and can tell the prospects what they need to know. Before prospects buy a product, they may want to know how it is made, how it works, what it will do, and what it will not do. Clearly, a first step in sales writing is careful study of your product or service.

As we have stressed, you must also study your readers. You should gather demographic, psychographic, and any other kind



## from the tech desk

### Learn about e-Selling from Chief Marketer and MailChimp

The use of digital media for sales campaigns has grown enormously over the last several years because of the increased popularity of these media and the devices people use to access them. If you'd like to learn more about the complex art and science of e-marketing, read on.

Chief Marketer's Web site ([www.chiefmarketer.com](http://www.chiefmarketer.com)) has great information about using technology to conduct effective email, Web, social, and mobile campaigns. Their researchers have gathered statistics about consumer behavior regarding each medium and developed marketing strategies based on that behavior. If you've been wanting to go behind the scenes and see how

the pros design electronic messages to sell through different channels, Chief Marketer is for you.

**Chief Marketer**

Source: [www.chiefmarketer.com](http://www.chiefmarketer.com)

If you're particularly interested in writing effective sales emails, let MailChimp show you how. This company specializes in conducting email sales campaigns. You can access excellent material on their "Resources" page ([mailchimp.com/resources](http://mailchimp.com/resources)), such as their guide to designing for mobile devices, mobile-friendly templates, and an "Email Marketing Benchmarks by Industry" report. Check

out their "Subject Line Comparison," which examined the open rates of 40 million emails and compared the subject lines of the best and worst performers.



Source: [mailchimp.com](http://mailchimp.com)



# communication matters

## Are Sales Letters Becoming Extinct? Absolutely Not!

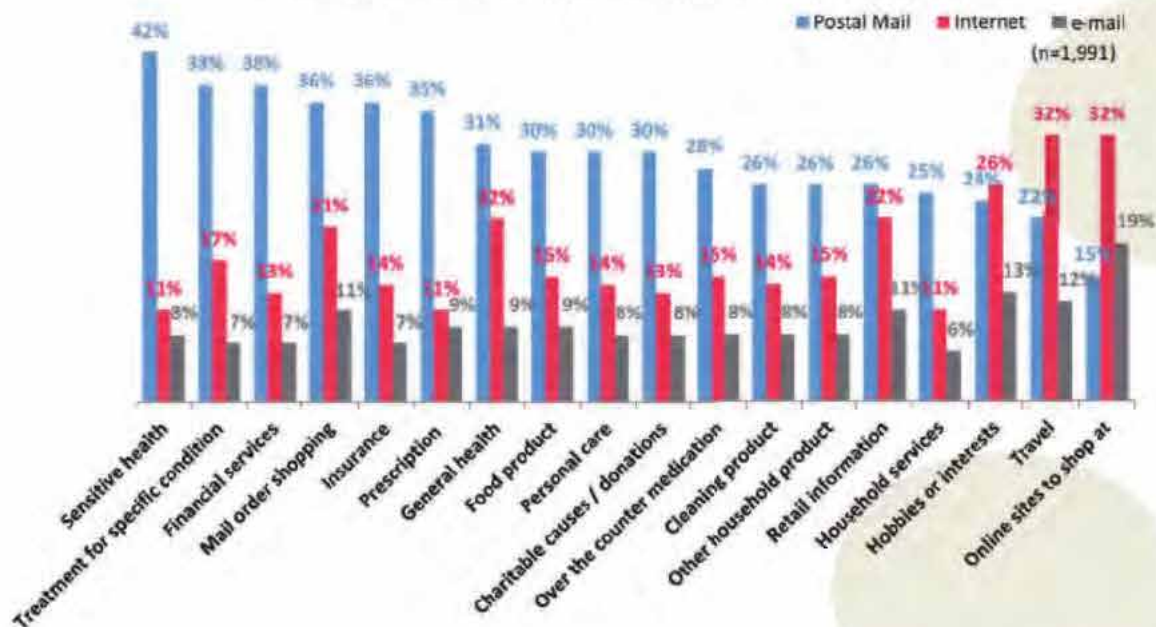
You might be wondering if digital media are making sales letters obsolete. While it's true that the volume of sales mailings has declined, print sales messages still have a lot going for them, as these sources attest:

- According to Tristan Loo of the marketing firm ProfitFuzion.com, direct mail has the highest rate of success in new customer acquisition as compared to other channels. Also, 65 percent of people who received direct mail made a purchase in 2012, and 22- to 24-year-olds were the consumers most likely to respond to a mail piece ("Direct Mail Statistics," 22 Nov. 2012, Web, 17 May 2013).
- An article in *Forbes* magazine reports that physical mail has certain advantages over electronic mail. It "leaves a 'deeper footprint' in the brain because it involves more emotional processing, connects better with readers' feelings, and evokes more emotionally vivid memories" (Steve Olenski, "In the Land of Digital, Let's Not Forget the Physical," 18 Oct. 2011, Web, 17 May 2013).
- A study by the marketing firm Epsilon found that "a majority of consumers still prefer postal mail for a large portion of their multichannel communication." Interestingly, their preferences for physical mail are stronger in

some industries than in others, as shown in the chart below.

To be effective, though, sales mailings should be part of an "integrated multichannel communication plan," advises marketer Beth Negus Viveiros. You also need a well-researched mailing list, writing that is targeted to your specific readers, and content that clearly differentiates you from the competition ("Make Mail Part of Your 2013 Integrated Marketing Plan," *Chief Marketer*, 15 Nov. 2012, Web, 17 May 2013).

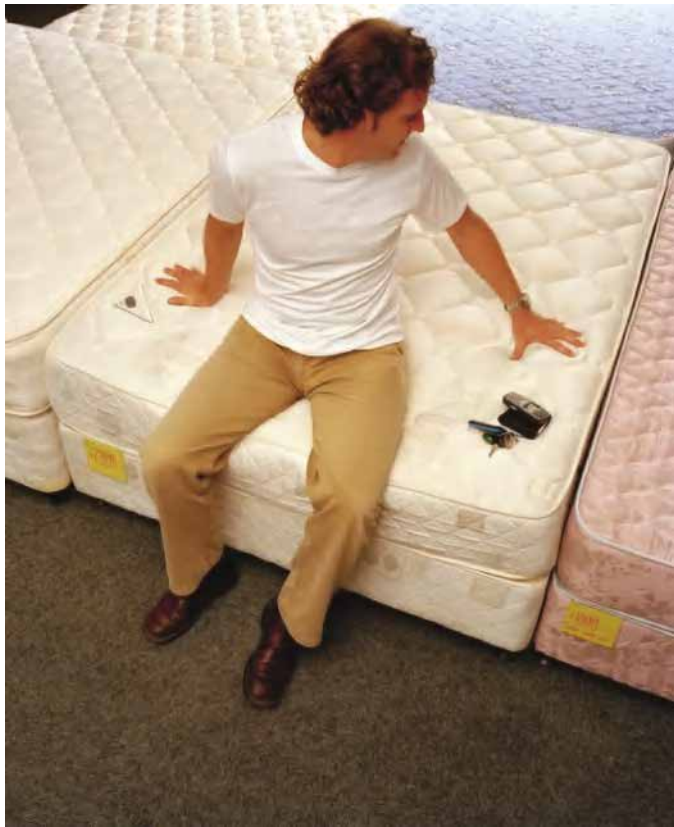
Stated Preference for Receiving Information (US)



Source: Epsilon, *Channel Preferences for Both the Mobile and Non-Mobile Consumer*, Epsilon.com, Epsilon Data Management, LLC, 2012, Web, 17 May 2013. Reprinted with permission.

of information that will help you understand why they might want or need your product. The more you know about your readers, the better you will be able to adapt your sales message to them. (Read about consumers' different media preferences by industry in the Communication Matters box above.)

In large businesses, a marketing research department or agency typically gathers information about prospective customers. If you do not have such help, you will need to gather this information on your own. If time does not permit you to do the necessary research, you may have to use



*Begin work on a sales message by thoroughly studying the product or service to be sold.*

logic and imagination. For example, the nature of a product can tell you something about its likely buyers. Industrial equipment would probably be bought by people with technical backgrounds. Expensive French perfumes and cosmetics would probably be bought by people in high-income brackets. Long-term care insurance would appeal to older people in middle-income brackets.

To be able to choose the most persuasive channel for your message, you should familiarize yourself with all the sales media that are now available. Often times, several media will need to work together to have the best effect. These days, sales emails are often linked to Web sites, and Web sites often provide links to social networking sites. You may even decide that the best approach is to start with an email and follow up with a phone call, or speak face to face with a prospect and then hand him or her some sales literature. There have never been so many media available, and the more you know about them, the better your selling can be.

“To be able to choose the most persuasive channel for your message, you should familiarize yourself with all the sales media that are now available.”

## Determining the Central Appeal

With your product or service, your prospects, and your medium or media in mind, you are ready to create the sales message. This involves selecting and presenting your persuasive appeals, whether emotional, logical, character based, or a combination. But for most sales messages, one appeal should stand out as the main one—mentioned in the beginning, recalled in the middle, and reiterated at the end. While other benefits can be brought in as appropriate, the message should emphasize your central, best appeal.

Emotional appeals—those based on our senses and emotions—can be found in almost any sales message, but they predominate in messages for goods and services that do not perform any discernable rational function. The following example illustrates:

Linger in castle corridors on court nights in London. Dance on a Budapest balcony high above the blue Danube. Seek romance and youth and laughter in charming capitals on five continents. And there you'll find the beguiling perfume that is fragrance *Jamais*.

Logical appeals are useful for selling products that help readers save money, do a better job, or get better use from a product. Illustrating a rational appeal (saving money) are these words from a message selling magazine subscriptions:

We're slashing the regular rate of \$36 a year down to only \$28, saving you a full 22 percent. That means you get 12 information-filled new issues of *Science Digest* for only \$2.33 a copy. You save even more by subscribing for 2 or 3 years.

Character-based appeals can enhance any kind of sales message. They persuade by stating or implying “I use this product, so you should, too” or “I am an authority, so you should do what I recommend.” Ads that employ sports figures, film stars, or experts to sell their products are relying heavily on character-based appeals. Companies themselves often project an appealing “character” in their sales campaigns. Note how the following excerpt from a sales letter for *Consumer Reports* magazine uses the company's identity to persuade:

*Consumer Reports* is on your side. We're a nonprofit consumer protection organization with no commercial interests whatsoever. To put it bluntly, we don't sell out to big companies and private

interest groups—we're accountable to no one except to consumers. And when you're not beholden to advertisers (like other so-called consumer protection publications), you can tell it like it is.

People may also buy a certain product because they want to identify with, and be identified with, a certain successful,





A well-known spokesperson can add character appeal. Here, actress Bella Thorne represents Wallflower Jeans.

socially responsible, or “cool” company as projected in the company’s sales messages.

In any given case, many appeals are available to you. You should use those that fit your product or service and your readers best. Keep in mind that how the buyer will use the product may be a major basis for selecting a sales strategy. For example, cosmetics might well be sold to the final user through emotional appeals, but selling cosmetics to a retailer (who is primarily interested in reselling them) would require rational appeals. A retailer’s main questions about the product would be “Will it sell? What turnover can I expect? How much money will it make for me?”

## Determining the Makeup of the Mailing

When you write a sales message to be sent by mail or email, a part of your effort is to determine the makeup of the mailing. To know what you want to say in your main message, you’ll need to decide what kinds of additional pieces will be included and how they will support the main piece.

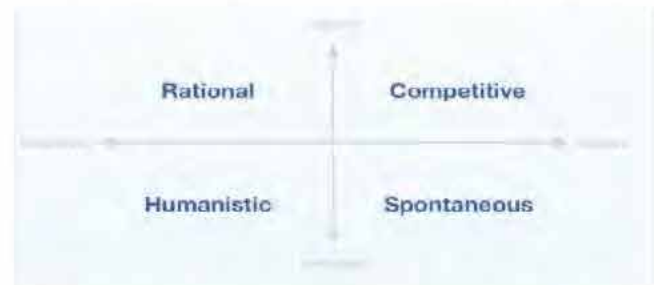
For example, the letter featured in the Case Illustration on page 175 came with a second page that included a detailed agenda for the workshop, as well as a list of management skills the attendees would learn. Moving this material to a second

# communication matters

## What Type of Decision Maker Is Your Reader?

As a consumer, are you more emotional or more logical? And do you make your purchases quickly or deliberately?

According to Des Traynor, an expert on customer acquisition and management, how your potential customers would answer these questions will put them in one of the following four quadrants:



When you know your readers’ likely decision-making style, you can choose the most appropriate sales materials for them, as shown here:



So select and design your sales materials with your readers’ decision-making style(s) in mind.

Source: “Know Your Customers and How They Decide,” *Inside Intercom*, Intercom, Inc., n. d., Web, 16 May 2013. Reprinted with permission.

page enabled the writer to keep the letter itself relatively short and fast moving. Many sales and fundraising mailings are even more elaborate, including brochures, giveaways, order forms, and more, like the National Audubon Society mailing on page 172. You will need to plan what to include and in what form. Even if someone else, such as a graphic artist or desktop publishing expert, will be designing the pieces of your mailing, you will need to be able to explain what you want and plan how all parts of the sales package will work together, especially for a complex mailing like the one described here.





Direct-mail messages can include many extras beyond the main message.

Email sales messages can use all the publishing features available on the computer. Like the Case Illustration on page 179, the message can be presented creatively with color, font variations, box arrangements, artwork, and more. It may include links to the seller's Web site as well as to other supporting material and to the ordering procedure. And it may have attachments. Just as with a direct-mail package, the email sales package can use many elements to persuade and to provide all the information a reader will need in order to make a purchase.

**LO 7-5** Compose sales messages that gain attention, present persuasive appeals, use appropriate visual elements, and effectively drive for action.

## Gaining Attention Before the Message Begins

Sales messages must gain the reader's attention right away. Otherwise, they won't be read. For this reason, the sales effort often begins before the actual message does.

Many mailed messages have an attention getter on the envelope. It may be the offer of a gift ("Your gift is enclosed"). It may present a brief sales message ("12 months of *Time* at 60 percent off the newsstand price"). It may present a picture and a message (a picture of a cruise ship and "Tahiti and more at 2-for-1 prices"). An official-looking envelope sometimes is used. So are brief and simple messages such as "Personal" or "Sensitive material enclosed."

With email, of course, there is no envelope. The effort to gain attention begins with the *From* and *Subject* information. To avoid having your message

### EXHIBIT 7-2 Can Your Sales Message Pass This Test?

Jim Logan of Sales 2.0, a sales consulting firm, advises writers to read the first two paragraphs and the last paragraph of their sales messages and then see if the readers can answer the following five questions:

1. What is this entire thing about?
2. Why should I care?
3. What am I being asked to do?
4. Why should I believe any of this?
5. How do I do it?

If they can't, your message isn't reader centered enough.

Source: "A Terrible One-Page Sales Letter," *Sales 2.0*, Sales 2.0 LLC, n. d., Web, 16 May 2013.

regarded as spam, you should clearly tell who you are and identify your company. You should also address the reader by name. Though some readers will delete the message even with this clear identification, the specificity will induce some to read on.

The subject line in email messages is the main place for getting attention. Here honesty and simplicity should be your guide. The subject line should tell clearly what your message is about, and it should be short. It should avoid sensational wording, such as "How to earn \$60,000 the first month." In addition, avoiding sensationalism involves limiting the use of solid caps, exclamation points, dollar signs, and "free" offers. In fact, you risk having spam filters block your message or send it to the recipient's junk folder if you use "free" or other words and phrases commonly used in spam. An email with the subject line "Making your restaurant more profitable" that is sent to a researched list of restaurant managers and owners is much more likely to be opened and read than a message with the subject line "You have to read this!" that is sent to thousands of readers.



The envelope often begins the persuasive effort.



## Gaining Attention in the Opening of the Message

The first words of your message must also gain attention and motivate the reader to keep reading. What you do here can be creative, but the method you use should help set up your strategy. It should not just gain attention for attention's sake. Attention is easy to gain if nothing else is needed. In a sales letter, a sensational statement such as "You can be a millionaire!" or "Free chocolate for the rest of your life!" would gain attention, but it wouldn't be likely to help sell most products or services, which can't live up to such extravagant claims.

One of the most effective attention-gaining openings is a statement or question that introduces a need that the product will satisfy. For example, this rational-appeal opening would be likely to tap into a retailer's main need:

Here is a proven best-seller—and with a 12 percent greater profit.

This paragraph of a message selling a fishing vacation at a lake resort illustrates a need-fulfilling beginning of an emotional-appeal approach:

Your line hums as it whirs through the air. Your line splashes and dances across the smooth surface of the clear water as you reel. From the depth you see the silver streak of a striking bass. You feel a sharp tug. The battle is on!

A different tack is illustrated by the following example. It attracts interest by telling a story and using character-based appeal:

In 1984 three enterprising women met to do something about the lack of accessible health information for women.

Whatever opening strategy you choose, it should lead into your central selling point.

## Building a Persuasive Case

With the reader's attention gained, you proceed with the sales strategy that you have planned. In general, you establish a need. Then you present your product or service as fulfilling that need.

The plan of your sales message will vary with each case. But it is likely to follow certain general patterns determined by your choice of appeals. If your main appeal is emotional, for example, your opening has probably established an emotional atmosphere that you will continue to develop. Thus, you will sell your product based on its effects on your reader's senses. You will describe the appearance, texture, aroma, and taste of your product so vividly that your reader will mentally see it, feel it—and want it. In general, you will seek to create an emotional need for your product.

If you select a rational appeal as your central theme, your sales description is likely to be based on factual material. You should describe your product based on what it can do for your reader rather than how it appeals to the senses. You should

## communication matters

### Gaining—and Keeping—Readers' Attention on Facebook and Twitter

Messages on Facebook and Twitter don't use envelopes or subject lines, so how do you gain attention in these media? Monica Clarke of The Wakeman Agency, a New York-based public relations firm serving nonprofits and small to medium-sized businesses, has some advice.

If you can afford it, hire a celebrity spokesperson; "co-branding or collaborating with a 'star' may give your cause the spark it needs." But if that's not feasible, use television ads, magazine ads, your website, and other outlets to start a buzz.

Once you have people logged in, "the major effort must be focused on not losing their attention." Keep the feeds coming, and provide content "that will get people talking to their friends about your social media marketing campaign." Find an interesting angle "and work it—don't just provide information about your organization, but provide information about the bigger picture." Just setting up a Facebook or Twitter account and hoping for followers is a surefire way to become "just another '@' symbol in the crowd."

**Source:** "Standing Out Amongst Millions—How to Get Attention on Twitter and Facebook," *The Wakeman Agency*, The Wakeman Agency, n.d., Web, 20 May 2013.

write matter-of-factly about such qualities as durability, savings, profits, and ease of operation.

When using character-based appeals, you will emphasize comments from a well-known, carefully selected spokesperson. Or, if the character being promoted is that of the company itself, you will provide evidence that your company is expert and dependable, understands customers like "you," and stands behind its service or product.

The writing that carries your sales message can be quite different from your normal business writing. Sales writing usually is highly conversational, fast moving, and aggressive. It even uses techniques that are incorrect or inappropriate in other forms of business writing, such as sentence fragments or catchy slang. As the Case Illustrations show, it also uses visual emphasis devices (underscore, capitalization, boldface, italics, exclamation marks, color) and a variety of type sizes and fonts. And its paragraphing often appears choppy. Any sales message is competing with many other messages for the intended reader's attention. In this environment of information overload, punchy writing and visual effects that enable quick processing of the message's main points have become the norm in professional sales writing.



## case illustration

# A Direct-Mail Message (Selling a Lawn Care Service)

With an emphasis on character-based appeals, this attractive letter builds a central argument: Only the experts at Scotts can give you the results you want. Inside the mailing were two pages of additional

appeals and information—with pictures of luscious green grass, of course.



Make your lawn a Scotts® Lawn.  
Get a Free Lawn Analysis.

---

FREE Lawn Analysis for  
Primary Address 2-----

---

Priority Cod : XXXXXXXX

*The letter can be filled in with the reader's information for a personal touch.*

The Lastname Household-----  
 Firm Name (Float Up) - - - - -  
 Sec Add (Float Up) -----  
 Pr Add (Float Up) -----  
 Csz (Float Up) -----  
 Variable Date -----

*The attention getter is featured twice for emphasis.*

All lawn services are not the same. Scotts LawnService® has new programs to help your lawn and your budget

*The main theme of the letter is highlighted here.*

Dear (Insert Name)

Here's a familiar story. At one point, another lawn service company promised you a perfect lawn without weeds. The lawn pictured in their ad looked nice and you signed up. Now, here are days when you drive away from your house, glance at your lawn, and wonder why you even bothered. You deserve better, your lawn deserves better—and Scotts LawnService has new programs that can help.

*The story and the scenario painting engage the reader and continue the letter's theme.*

Look inside to see the variety of programs we offer to give you a Scotts Lawn. Everything from basic maintenance to "best on the block" quality, you'll find Scotts LawnService is more flexible—and more affordable—than you might expect.

Don't take chances with anyone else.

*The main theme is repeated, with added emotional appeal.*

**Only Scotts LawnService has:**

- Access to Scotts' research and development team the largest and most experienced in the industry.
- A system of professional products from the Scotts Miracle-Gro® family of brands that no one else has—including our competition.
- Exclusive WaterSmart® formulation, which improves your lawn's ability to absorb water, nutrients and weed controls by up to 25%, giving you a greener lawn and fewer weeds.
- Exclusive Weed B Gon® EdgeGuard™ which reinforces weed barriers to provide up to 75% more weed control along your sidewalks and driveway, where weeds seem to creep up the most.

*This readable list of benefits uses all three types of appeals, with the emphasis on character-based appeal (Scott's unmatched expertise).*

Along with our industry-leading products and services, only our lawn technicians have been trained at the Scotts LawnService Training Institute™ So you'll never worry about an untrained part-timer working on your lawn.

Scotts LawnService offers a Complete Satisfaction Guarantee for every one of our customers: we're not satisfied until you are. And when you get started with Scotts LawnService, we promise to never charge you a start-up fee—unlike some of our competitors

Call 800-728-4940 or go online in the next 14 days to request your Free Lawn Analysis. Let us give you a genuine Scotts Lawn—and make the other guys' empty promises a thing of the past.

*The call to action is clear and linked to the letter's theme.*

Sincerely,

(Name)  
 (Insert Branch Manager)  
 (Insert Branch Name)

*Having the letter come from a local manager adds more personalization.*

*This visually appealing invitation leads to additional persuasive facts.*

P.S. Go online to get your Free Lawn Analysis at mySLS.com

*The P.S. repeats the call to action in "you" language.*

**Learn more about  
The Scotts Advantage®**

*inside*



## case illustration

# A Direct-Mail Message (Selling a Management Seminar)

This sales letter uses all three types of appeals (logical, emotional, and character based). The mailing included a second page that provided

a detailed outline of the seminar and a longer list of likely reader benefits.

**SKILLPATH® SEMINARS**  
a division of The Graceland College Center for Professional Development and Lifelong Learning, Inc.

P.O. Box 2768 • Mission, KS 66201-2768  
1-800-873-7545 Fax: 1-913-362-4241

PREFERRED CUSTOMER # A0000000  
VIP # 28055 - 999700 - 1JC0 - 4

\*\*\*\*\*ECRL0T\*\*C-004

Mr. Joe Doe  
University of Cincinnati  
579 Terrace Ave.  
Cincinnati, OH, 45220-1916

|||||

*The compass suggests finding the right direction.*

*Two headlines in different formats target the reader's needs and attract attention.*

*Learn the essential skills you need to accomplish anything—through anyone*

**Get what you need to succeed as a manager or supervisor**

**Dear Joe,**

Being a successful manager or supervisor requires a new set of skills—a *different* set of skills than those that got you where you are today. Maybe you don't have the title, but do have the responsibilities. Either way, you know that making the leap from worker to supervisor can be extremely rewarding—or a big disappointment if you're not grounded in solid supervisory fundamentals.

*Catchy, succinct writing generates interest.*

Making the transition from "doing the work" to "making sure the work gets done" is a big one. That's why I'd like to invite you or a colleague to attend ***Excelling as a Manager or Supervisor***. Making sure your supervisory skills are solid is our #1 goal in this intensive one-day workshop. It's full of concrete answers to the questions you have about fulfilling your management responsibilities confidently and credibly. There's no fluff here, just real-life "how-to's" like:

- why it's important to "take charge" and put your best foot forward—and a half-dozen tips to do just that
- how to make delegating a natural, comfortable part of your supervisory routine
- dealing with interruptions and other time robbers (the biggest complaint of supervisors everywhere!)

*The opening "understands" the reader and his situation.*

Correcting problem behavior, developing top-notch communication skills, motivating your workers to give 110%—with that kind of know-how under your belt, it's a sure bet that throughout your organization you'll enjoy the reputation of a well-respected supervisor known for results. What's more, you'll not only sidestep the school of hard knocks, you'll build true leadership capabilities—the kind that result in an energized and motivated staff you've developed!

*Scenario painting shows the reader enjoying the benefits.*

Take a look at the next page for a complete outline of the one-day workshop agenda ... for just \$149, you can set a course for a lifetime of supervisory excellence. You'll be able to attend ***Excelling as a Manager or Supervisor*** in:

Cincinnati, OH • August 6, 2013

SkillPath has trained over 10 million people worldwide since 1989. We'd like to be the training source you turn to for time-tested supervisory skills you can build your management career on. It's easy to enroll ... **register on-line at [www.skillpath.com](http://www.skillpath.com)** or with a quick phone call to 1-800-873-7545.

Cincinnati, OH • September 11, 2013

Enroll today; it'll be an investment in your success you'll be glad you made.

Sincerely,

*Robb*

Robb Garr  
President, SkillPath Seminars

*The requested action is clear and easy to perform.*

*The final sentence captures the letter's persuasive theme.*

**P.S. It's just \$149 to fully achieve your potential as a supervisor or manager. With our 100% satisfaction guarantee, there's absolutely no reason not to attend.**

*The price is stated as a smart bargain.*

*The letter is personalized for "Joe"—and giving the dates here keeps him from having to find them.*

*The P.S. repeats the most compelling point and helps ensure that the "100% guarantee" will be noticed.*



## Stressing the You-Viewpoint

In no area of business communication is the use of the you-viewpoint more important than in sales writing. A successful sales message bases its sales points on reader interest. You should liberally use and imply the pronoun *you* throughout the sales message as you present your well-chosen reader benefits.

For example, assume you are writing a sales message to a retailer and that one point you want to make is that the manufacturer will help sell the product with an advertising campaign. You could write this information in a matter-of-fact way: “HomeHealth products will be advertised in *Self* magazine for the next three issues.” Or you could write it based on what the advertising means to the reader: “Your customers will read about HomeHealth products in the next three issues of *Self* magazine.” As you can see, viewing things from the reader’s perspective strengthens your persuasiveness. The following examples further illustrate the value of presenting facts as reader benefits:

| Facts                                                                           | You-Viewpoint Statements                                                                                                                            |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| We make Aristocrat hosiery in three colors.                                     | You may choose from three lovely shades.                                                                                                            |
| The Regal weighs only a few ounces.                                             | The Regal’s featherlight touch makes vacuuming easier than ever.                                                                                    |
| Lime-Fizz is a lime-flavored carbonated beverage.                               | Your customers will keep coming back for the refreshing citrus taste of Lime-Fizz.                                                                  |
| Baker’s Dozen is packaged in a rectangular box with a bright bull’s-eye design. | Baker’s Dozen’s new rectangular package fits compactly on your shelf, and its bright bull’s-eye design is sure to catch the eyes of your customers. |

You may also want to make use of scenario painting, putting the reader in a simulated context that brings out the product’s

## Choosing Words Carefully

In persuasive messages, every word can influence whether the reader will act on your request. Try putting yourself in your reader’s place as you select words for your message. Some words, while closely related in meaning, have different emotional effects. For example, the word *selection* implies a choice, while the word *preference* implies a first choice. Consider how changing a single adjective changes the effect of these sentences:

The NuPhone’s *small* size . . .

The NuPhone’s *compact* size . . .

The NuPhone’s *sleek* size . . .

Framing your requests in the positive is also a proven persuasive technique. Readers will tend to opt for solutions to problems that avoid negatives. Here are some examples:

| Original Wording                                                                       | Positive Wording                                                            |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Tastee ice cream has nine grams of fat per serving.                                    | Tastee ice cream is 95 percent fat free.                                    |
| Our new laser paper keeps the wasted paper from smudged copies to less than 2 percent. | Our new laser paper ensures smudge-free copies over 98 percent of the time. |

## Enhancing Your Message with Visuals

The Web has made today’s readers more visually oriented than any before in history. When preparing any kind of sales message, be sure to consider whether photos, tables, boxes, word art, borders, or other graphical elements would enhance your message’s appeal.

In no area of business communication is the use of the you-viewpoint more important than in sales writing.

appeal. The J. Peterman company is famous for this technique, exemplified in the following excerpt from an advertisement for a picnic backpack:

It’s a 7-mile hike to Snowmass Lake.

Best do it in late spring, early summer.

At sunset, the orange hues of Snowmass Mountain reflect off this glassy, ripple free water. Many stop here to rest before a summit run.

Audrey and I are here for a picnic. No further quest required, less equipment, too. I have the overnight gear. She, this perfectly equipped lightweight picnic backpack.

As pointed out earlier, sales letters can contain elaborately designed materials. Often, the envelope will contain artful text and images. Inside, you’ll find visual elements ranging from logos and creatively chosen fonts to photos of products and customers.

Email sales messages have become just as visually appealing, if not more so. Many that sell products are almost all pictures; others are at the opposite end of the spectrum, such as some email messages designed to be read on mobile devices (see the contrasting Delta Airlines messages on page 178). Probably most fall somewhere in between these two extremes, like the Case Illustration on page 179.

# communication matters

## Current Trends in Promotional Writing: A Q&A with a Young PR Professional

Kelly Gadd began working for the Eisen Agency, a PR firm in Cincinnati, Ohio, right after graduation. Here she shares her view of today's promotional writing landscape.

**Q: How do current promotional strategies differ from those of, say, 10 years ago? What has changed?**

A: Certainly one significant change is the move toward digital promotions. Now, many consumers view promotional material exclusively through social media channels, Web sites, and email. Many companies make certain offers, events, or products available only to their loyal digital audiences to entice them to engage with their brands more frequently over these channels. Brands need to be wherever their customers want them whenever they need them.

An increase in experiential promotional tactics has also become popular. With consumers receiving more than 5,000 marketing



messages each day, it's hard for brands to stand out with traditional promotions. Whether through special events, street teams, or a traveling display, companies want to create an experience that consumers can't ignore.

**Q: What persuasion principles and strategies are still important, no matter what the medium?**

A: While the communication channels have changed, people still have the same basic needs, so persuasive appeals are still based on credibility, logic, and emotion. If anything, consumers' sensibilities have been heightened by the overwhelming access to information. In particular, the credibility of the

communicator or company has become more important. Since anyone can post whatever he/she likes online and call it accurate, consumers have had to become more skeptical and discerning—but they also are quicker to make decisions and less likely to fact check.

**Q: What advice would you give other young business professionals about promoting their companies' products or services?**

A: Familiarity with digital media is certainly a strength. However, I would caution today's young employees not to discount promotional and marketing strategies that have worked well for decades. Well-planned strategy is still the key to successful execution, and professionalism and good, solid writing skills are still very important. But be aware that information about your products/company will be available quickly, good or bad, so be as prepared as possible and put problem-solving skills to work when things do not go as planned.

The visual literacy you read about in Chapter 1 definitely comes into play when designing sales messages. You need to understand, for example, that a photo is not just a literal representation of a person or a product; it conveys a mood, a set of values, and even an experience. Where to put the visual elements is also an important decision, requiring that you imagine the readers' likely response to the screen or page design. Whatever visual elements you choose and wherever you put them, be sure that they project the desired message and complement the textual content.

## Including All Necessary Information

Of course, the information you present and how you present it are matters for your best judgment. But you must make sure that you present enough information to complete the sale. You should leave none of your readers' questions unanswered. Nor should you fail to overcome any likely objections. You must work to include all such information in your message, and you should make it clear and convincing.

You will also need to decide how to apportion your information across all the pieces in your mailing or the layout of a screen. With direct mail, you should use your letter to do most of the persuading, with any enclosures, attachments, or links providing supplementary information. These supplements might provide in-depth descriptions, price lists, diagrams, and pictures—in short, all the helpful information that does not fit easily into the letter. You may want to direct your readers' attention to these other pieces with such comments as “you'll find comments from your satisfied neighbors in the enclosed brochure,” “as shown on page 7 of the enclosed catalog,” or “you'll see testimonials of satisfied customers in our brochure.”

When you send the sales message by email, the supporting information can be worked into the message, accessed via Web links, or provided in attachments that you invite the reader to view. Because people skim email quickly, be sure to keep the message itself relatively short. Skillfully chunking the message visually (see the Case Illustration on page 179) also helps reduce the impression of excessive length.





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Many sales emails today are designed to be displayed in two formats, one for a computer screen and one for a mobile device. As you see here, the large-screen version can be graphically rich, but the mobile version might include text and links only.

Source: Delta Airlines. Reprinted with permission.



## from the tech desk

### Visuals Help Business Writers Add Interest to Sales Messages

Sales messages—both print and rich email—often include art and animation to increase their visual appeal as well as attract attention to the message.

Today's business writers need not be artists or professional photographers to use good visuals in their documents. Major software programs include bundled art, animation, photographs, and sounds; and scanners and easy-to-use programs are readily available to help writers create customized visuals. Additionally, on the Web, writers can find a vast assortment of specialists with products and services to help enhance their sales messages.

Here is a short list of helpful Web sites. You'll find more on the textbook Web site as well.

#### • [www.wpclipart.com](http://www.wpclipart.com)

A wide range of free artwork in the public domain (available for you to use without permission).

#### • [www.stockfreeimages.com](http://www.stockfreeimages.com)

The largest Web collection of free images, with 856,030 images, stock photos, and illustrations.

#### • [www.corbisimages.com/](http://www.corbisimages.com/)

A gigantic collection of photos searchable by date, location, photographer, orientation, and more. Use of the images requires an up-front fee, but it is often quite low, and there's no royalty fee (a fee charged for each use of the image).

#### • [www.istockphoto.com](http://www.istockphoto.com)

Another popular source of royalty-free photos, but with illustrations, video, and audio available, too.

#### • [www.findsounds.com](http://www.findsounds.com)

The Web's leading source of sound files. Some are in the public domain (e.g., animal sounds), but others require that you obtain permission.

But a note of caution: If your favorite way to find an image is to search **Google Images**, be very wary of using these images in your own work. Many are protected by copyright—and it can be difficult to trace the source in order to ask permission to use the image.

## case illustration



# An Email Sales Message (Persuading Readers Who Used a Trial Version of an Application to Purchase It)

This message uses logical appeals and a variety of visual elements to make the product's benefits stand out.

**Use Your Snagit Captures Anywhere**

File Edit View Tools Message Help

Reply Reply All Forward Print Delete Forward Back Addresses

**From:** TechSmith  
**Date:** Monday, 5/14/2013 7:10 a.m.  
**To:** Kathryn Rentz  
**Subject:** Use Your Snagit Captures Anywhere

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TechSmith

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*Opening stresses the central selling point: ease of use*

*Bulleted list focuses on tasks that the reader would be likely to want to do*

*"Freebie" builds brand loyalty and the seller's credibility*

*Testimonial is given emphasis and visual interest*

*Call to action includes appealing information*

*Links encourage readers to stay informed and follow the brand*

Source: Reprinted with permission.



# communication matters

## Persuasive Strategies Vary across Cultures

When writing persuasive messages, be especially careful to adapt them to the culture of the intended readers.

For example, while sales letters in English and Chinese use many of the same core elements, there are also these crucial differences:

- English sales letters often use attention-getting headlines and postscripts that pressure readers to act, while Chinese sales letters do not use these aggressive strategies.
- Both types of letters contain a salutation, but it is more formal in Chinese letters (for example, “Honored Company” instead of “Dear Mr. Smith”). Furthermore, Chinese letters follow the salutation with polite words of greeting, whereas English letters go directly into sales talk.
- English letters tend to describe the product’s benefits by using “you,” whereas the Chinese, finding the use of “you” disrespectful, tend to use “we” (as in “Our consistent goal is to produce comfortable luxury cars of high standard and good quality”).
- Both types of letters extol the benefits of the product, but Chinese letters use fewer details, especially about price.
- When making the actual request, Chinese letters are less pushy than English letters, favoring such mild language as “If you are interested in our products, please contact us.”
- Both types of letters use a complimentary close, but instead of “Sincerely yours,” the Chinese attempt to promote cooperation and mutual respect with such closings as “Wishing good health.”

**Source:** Zhu Yunxia, “Building Knowledge Structures in Teaching Cross-Cultural Sales Genres,” *Business Communication Quarterly* 63.4 (2000): 49–69, print.

## Driving for the Sale

After you have developed your reader’s interest in your product or service, the next logical step is to drive for the sale. After all, this is what you have been working for all along. It is the natural conclusion to the previous paragraphs.

How to word your drive for the sale depends on your strategy. If your selling effort is strong, your drive for action also may be strong. It may even be worded as a command (“Order your copy today—while it’s on your mind.”). If you use a milder selling effort, you could use a direct question (“May we send you your copy today?”). In any event, the drive for action should be specific and

clear. For best effect, it should take the reader through the motions of whatever he or she must do. Here are some examples:

Just check your preferences on the enclosed order card and drop it in the mail today.

To start enjoying *House and Garden*, just call 1-888-755-5265. Be sure to have promo code 3626 handy to receive your 40 percent discount.

Similarly, in email selling you will need to make the action easy. Make it a simple click—a click to an order form or to the first part of the ordering process. For example, you might say “Just click the button below to order your customized iPhone case now!” or “You can download our free new catalog of business gifts at <http://thankyoutoo.com>.” Many sales emails, such as the one shown on the next page, make the desired action easy by including multiple places for readers to perform it.

Because readers who have been persuaded sometimes put things off, you should urge immediate action. “Do it now” and “Act today” are versions of this technique, although some people dislike the commanding tone of such words. A milder and generally more acceptable way of urging action is to tie it in with a good reason for acting now. Here are some examples:

. . . to take advantage of this three-day offer.

. . . so that you can be ready for the Christmas rush.

. . . so that you can immediately begin enjoying. . .

Another effective technique for the close of a sales message is to use a few words that recall the main appeal. Associating the action with the benefits that the reader will gain by taking it adds strength to your sales effort. Illustrating this technique is a message selling a fishing resort vacation that follows its action words with a reminder of the joys described earlier:

It’s your reservation for a week of battle with the fightingest bass in the Southland.

## Adding a Postscript

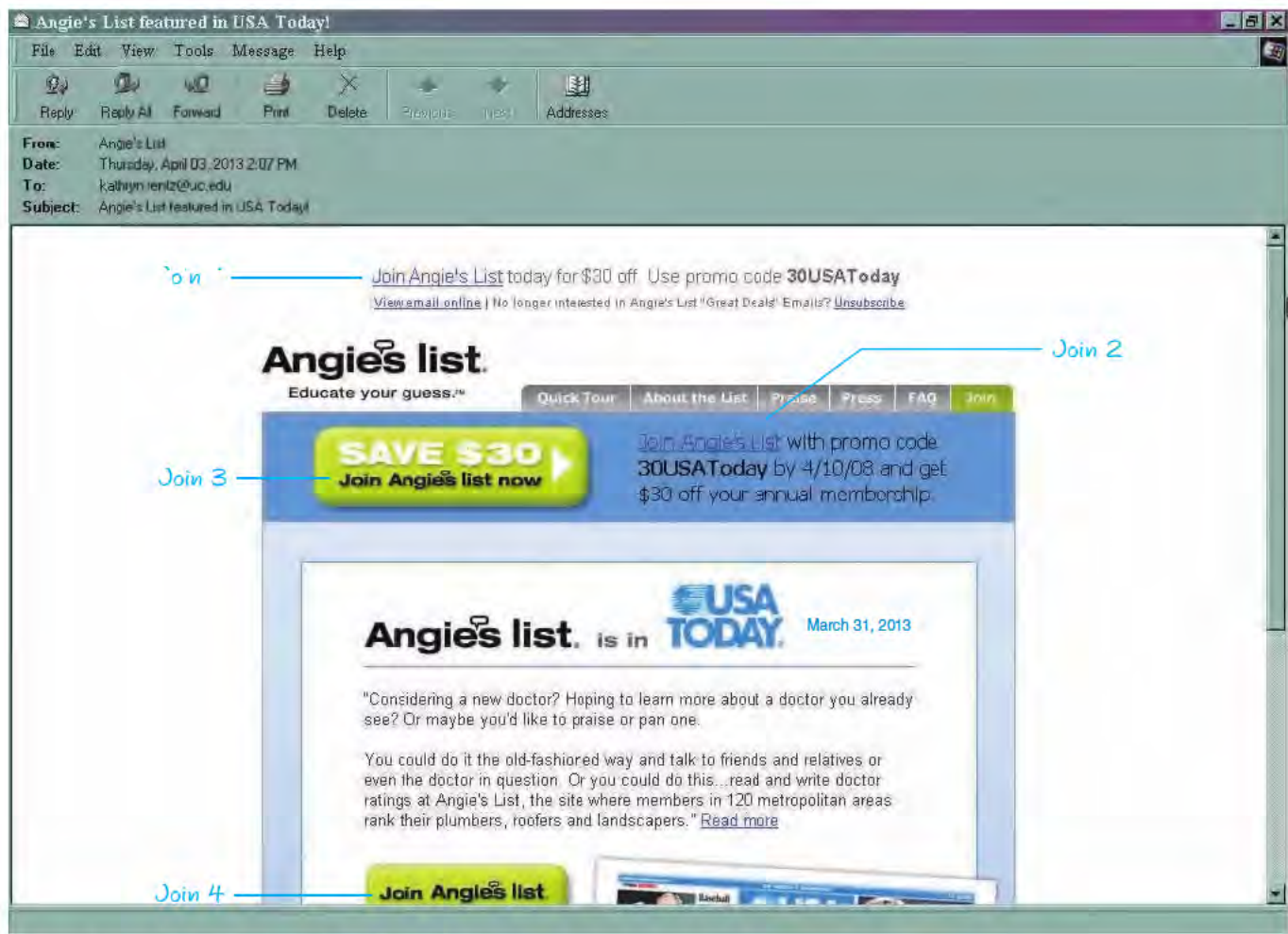
Unlike other business messages where a postscript (P.S.) appears to be an afterthought, a sales message can use a postscript as a part of its design. It can be used effectively in a number of ways: to urge the reader to act, to emphasize the major appeal, to invite attention to other enclosures, or to suggest that the reader pass along the sales message. Postscripts effectively used by professionals include the following:

PS: Remember—if ever you think that *Action* is not for you, we’ll give you every cent of your money back. We are that confident that *Action* will become one of your favorite magazines.

PS: Hurry! Save while this special money-saving offer lasts.

PS: Our little magazine makes a distinctive and appreciated gift. Know someone who’s having a birthday soon?

PS: Click now to order and you’ll automatically be entered into a contest for a 4G Android smartphone.



*This email sales message makes the desired action easy.*

Source: Reprinted with permission.

## Offering Name Removal to Email Readers

Until January 1, 2004, it was a courtesy to offer the recipients of commercial email the option of receiving no further emails from the sender. Now, thanks to the so-called CAN-SPAM Act, it is a legal requirement as well (see Exhibit 7-3).<sup>4</sup> Consider placing this invitation in a prominent place—perhaps even before the main message. Wherever it is, the link should be easy to identify.

Ideally, it should also take only one or two clicks to work. Unfortunately, a 2010 report indicated that this trend was going in the wrong direction: The unsubscribe function of nearly half of the retail emails studied required three or more clicks, which was an increase from the year before.<sup>5</sup> On the other hand, providing readers the option of being emailed less frequently, of receiving emails about certain products only, or of following the brand through another channel (e.g., Facebook) seems to be regarded favorably by both consumers and businesses.<sup>6</sup>

### EXHIBIT 7-3 CAN-SPAM: It's the Law

The CAN-SPAM Act doesn't apply just to bulk email; it covers all commercial email messages whose purpose is to promote a product or service. Here are its main requirements:

1. Don't use false or misleading header information.
2. Don't use deceptive subject lines.
3. Identify the message as an ad.
4. Tell recipients where you're located (i.e., a physical postal address).
5. Tell recipients how to opt out of future email from you.
6. Honor opt-out requests promptly.
7. Be sure your email sales contractor (if you've hired one) is following the law.



## Reviewing the General Sales Plan

From the preceding discussion, a general plan for the sales message emerges. This plan is similar to the classic AIDA (attention, interest, desire, action) model developed almost a century ago. It should be noted, however, that in actual practice, sales messages vary widely. Creativity and imagination are continually leading to innovative techniques. Even so, the most common plan is the following:

- Gain favorable attention.
- Create desire by presenting the appeals, emphasizing supporting facts, emphasizing the reader's viewpoint, and enhancing the message with appropriate visual elements.
- Include all necessary information—using a coordinated sales package (brochures, leaflets, links, and other appended parts).
- Drive for the sale by urging action now and recalling the main appeal.
- Possibly add a postscript.
- In email writing, offer to remove the reader from your email list to comply with legal requirements.

## Contrasting Examples of a Sales Message

The following two email sales messages show bad and good efforts to promote Zach Miller's painting business (described in the Workplace Scenario on page 167).



This me-focused message is short on appealing reader benefits.

Subject: Offer from a Student

Hello,

My name is Zach Miller, and I'm a business student here at North Rapids University. I've been learning about business not only in the classroom but on the job, by running my own house-painting operation.

If you'd like to have your house painted this summer, I can do it for considerably less than what you'd pay a professional service. I would carefully prepare your house for painting, and I use good-quality paint. My two friends and I will also guarantee to complete the job within three days (weather permitting).

Please email me if you'd like an estimate.

Sincerely,  
Zach Miller

**a weak, self-centered message** The ineffective example, below, begins with a dull, vague subject line. The first sentence talks only about the writer and delays answering the reader's obvious question, "What's the offer?" The second sentence begins to hint at the topic, but it is still writer focused. The middle paragraph contains some potentially good logical points, but the general, bland language won't generate much enthusiasm. Also, the character appeal is weak. Zach comes across as just another struggling student trying to pay his way through school; he does not make a convincing case that he and his friends would actually do a good job. The final sentence doesn't tell the reader what information to include in a response—and no final selling ends the message.

## skillful use of character and rational appeals

The better message (next page) follows the advice presented in the preceding pages. The subject line contains concrete reader benefits and states right away that the job will be professionally done. The opening sentence is an engaging question and is again focused on key benefits. The second paragraph builds confidence in the writer and his co-workers, and it ends by allaying any worries that the homeowner will be held liable if one of the students is injured. The third paragraph provides convincing logical details about the job. In the final paragraph, the writer uses a Web link to make it easy for readers to submit an estimate request, and he directs them to an attachment that contains further information and one last reader benefit.